# The Waterfront Brief

Weekly sustainment intelligence for naval shipyard leadership · Naval shipbuilding, ship repair, and fleet sustainment

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A Rota-based destroyer entered dry dock at Navantia's Cadiz yard on October 7, the first in Europe since the Rota destroyers arrived. The Navy has docked its forward-deployed ships in its own Yokosuka docks for decades; what is new is a commercial yard doing it where the Navy has no dock. The two submarine tenders at Guam date from 1979, the Navy asked for two replacements, and Congress has so far given three answers: two ships on spread payments, one ship, and half the money with no count. Boxer's maintenance was due to end this month, and the next period, awarded in August, ends in October 2028. Norfolk technicians are fixing deployed ships over video, with the sailor doing the hands-on work. And the plan to put steam catapults on the carrier Doris Miller was due October 12 and nothing public says it arrived. In the sixty days since the order the Navy's chief and the shipbuilder both called steam a significant design change, and the Navy signed the electromagnetic system's parts maker to a sustainment contract through 2031.

How to read this: where a sentence names where something came from, those words are a link to the source itself, and the sentence says what that source says. A sentence with no link is this desk's analysis, built only on the linked facts above it. Two warnings are still written out in the text: Speculation, and Unverified for a claim nobody here could check against a primary source, with the reason it could not be checked.

## WATERFRONT OPS & PRODUCTION

### A Rota destroyer is in a Spanish commercial dock, a first for the Rota ships

On October 7 the Navy put a Rota-based destroyer into a dry dock at Navantia's Cadiz yard, the first docking in the 6th Fleet area since the Rota destroyers arrived. That is the only first on the record: the Navy has docked forward ships in Japan for decades, in its own docks and in a shared one, and a Korean commercial yard has overhauled a Navy supply ship. What changes is where six destroyers' dockings are done while the ships are forward.

The Navy said on October 8 that USS Arleigh Burke entered dry dock at Navantia's Cadiz shipyard on October 7. It called that "the first such evolution in the U.S. 6th Fleet area of operations" since the Rota destroyers arrived.

Japan has had this for a long time. The Yokosuka repair facility's own history page says, as read 2026-10-16, that United States forces opened it in 1947 and that it and its Sasebo detachment are home to 22 forward-deployed ships. The same page says its "six dry docks with a combined displacement of 530,000 tons" can "support timely dry-docking of most ships in the U.S. Navy inventory."

Sasebo docks ships in a dock the Navy does not own. NAVSEA said in August 2021 that its Sasebo detachment had finished USS Pioneer's seven-month docking availability three days early. It said "three of these four ships have undergone extensive work in Sasebo's dry dock" within 16 months. Unverified: that dock is Sasebo Heavy Industries' second dock, "provided as a shared facility for the US Navy and the Maritime Self-Defense Force," according to the company's Wikipedia entry as read 2026-10-16; no Navy page read names the dock's owner.

Korea has had a supply ship. The Navy said on March 13, 2025 that the Military Sealift Command supply ship Wally Schirra had completed a seven-month regular overhaul at Hanwha Ocean the day before. It called that "the first time that a Republic of Korea shipyard has bid on and won" an overhaul of that scale.

At Cadiz the Navy's own people are in the yard. The Navy's release said that Forward Deployed Regional Maintenance Center military and civilian personnel and the ship's crew "are working alongside industry partners at Navantia to execute planned maintenance and modernization." It quoted Vice Adm. J.T. Anderson, commander, U.S. 6th Fleet: "By integrating dry docking into planned maintenance periods overseas, the Navy is increasing material readiness for our forward-deployed warships."

The detachment and the contractor are not new to each other. NAVSEA said in March 2024 that the center's Rota detachment finished USS Roosevelt's depot-level period at Rota with Navantia and described the center's work as including "contract management oversight." Navantia said in a January 2021 release carried by Naval News that it had been "main maintainer of the US Navy in Rota" since 2013, under an agreement that would run to January 2028.

The ships are now six. The Navy's release said Arleigh Burke is one of five stationed at Rota. The 6th Fleet said on October 14 that USS John Basilone

arrived at Rota, its new homeport, from Mayport that day.

The Navy has not published the work list, the length, the cost or the completion date.

Set Cadiz beside Yokosuka, Sasebo and Hanwha Ocean and it is not a new method. A Navy detachment overseeing a contractor's work in a dock the Navy does not own is what Sasebo has run for years, and a Korean yard has had a Navy supply ship for seven months. It is a new place and six more hulls. The commander's words describe a process, so expect the other five Rota destroyers to follow if this docking finishes to plan, and expect their dockings to stay at Cadiz while the ships are forward. The limit on repeating it is the detachment's overseers, not dock space.

WHY IT MATTERS

**Bottom line:** If the Rota destroyers sit anywhere in a stateside yard's docking forecast, take them out for as long as the ships are forward, and size dock weeks and trades to the hulls that are coming. There is nothing to chase here; the only number that moves is how many forward hulls dock abroad, and it just went from the Japan ships to the Japan ships plus six.

*Sources: U.S. Navy, Oct 8, 2026; NAVSEA, SRF-JRMC history page, as read Oct 16, 2026; NAVSEA, Aug 5, 2021; Wikipedia, Sasebo Heavy Industries, as read Oct 16, 2026; U.S. Navy, Mar 13, 2025; U.S. 6th Fleet, Oct 14, 2026; NAVSEA, Mar 29, 2024; Navantia via Naval News, Jan 26, 2021*

## OPERATIONS MAINTENANCE & READINESS

### Guam's two submarine tenders date from 1979, and Congress has given three answers on replacing them

Both Navy submarine tenders date from 1979 and are past their service lives, the Navy says. The House authorized two replacements with payments spread, the Senate Armed Services Committee reported one, and House appropriators recommended half the money.

The Navy's May 2026 shipbuilding plan buys two tenders in fiscal 2027 to "replace the two aging ships currently in the inventory", calls them "operating beyond their expected service lives", and lists neither for inactivation through fiscal 2031.

Inside Defense reported in July that the two-ship program is "a planned fiscal year 2027 new start", with both awards expected in April 2027, "according to budget documents".

The continuing resolution, H.R. 6500, bars Defense funds for such new production in section 102 through December 11.

The House passed its authorization bill, H.R. 8800, on July 22. As passed the House, section 126 allows contracts for "not more than two AS(X) submarine tenders" with incremental funding, and its table trims $500 million for that.

The Senate Armed Services Committee's bill, as reported June 15, authorizes $2.3 billion and strikes the second ship as "early to need".

House appropriators recommended $2.2 billion of the $4.4 billion in their June 26 report, the rest cut as a "program adjustment", with no ship count stated.

Section 1015 of the same Senate bill requires a report by March 1, 2027 on how many tenders are needed and whether expeditionary sea bases or amphibious transport docks could augment them, then a briefing by April 1.

The Pacific submarine force dates Emory S. Land's commissioning to July 7, 1979, and Frank Cable's to October 20, 1979.

The Navy said in a December 2025 release that Guam has its only two submarine tenders, that Emory S. Land provides "expeditionary intermediate-level maintenance", and that it "served as the Lead Tender from May 2025".

One is under contract. The Defense Department announced on February 13 a $73 million, 215-day overhaul of Military Sealift Command's tender Emory S. Land at Vigor Marine in Portland, planned from May 1 to an expected December 1.

Frank Cable's ran from arrival to return. A Navy photo shows Frank Cable arriving at Mare Island on November 2, 2022, and the Navy said it returned to Guam on October 6, 2023 "to resume our role as the lead maintenance activity".

Set the answers side by side and one ship first is the likely outcome. Only the House floor allowed two, with payments spread; the Senate committee struck the second and House appropriators put up half the money. The second ship waits on the count the Navy owes by March 1, 2027, a month before the award: watch that. The 1979 pair stays on either way, because the plan retires neither through 2031, and the lead maintenance role passes between the two, so whichever is in a yard the other carries it. The record is one 215-day contract and one absence from November 2022 to October 2023, not a cycle.

WHY IT MATTERS

**Bottom line:** Plan forward submarine work for one tender, not two, in any year either ship is in its own yard period, with the lead maintenance role passing to the ship that stays. No funded replacement arrives on any date a record gives, so the hand-off, not the replacement, is the thing to build into next year's plan.

*Sources: U.S. Navy Shipbuilding Plan, May 2026; Inside Defense, Jul 17, 2026; H.R. 6500, enrolled; H.R. 8800, as passed the House, Jul 22, 2026; S. 4784, as reported Jun 15, 2026; H. Rept. 119-715, Jun 26, 2026; Commander, Submarine Force, U.S. Pacific Fleet: Emory S. Land history; About USS Frank Cable; DVIDS, Dec 28, 2025; Department of War, Contracts for Feb. 13, 2026; DVIDS, Nov 5, 2022; DVIDS, Oct 12, 2023*

### Boxer's maintenance was due to end this month; the next period ends in October 2028

Boxer's maintenance was due to end this month, by NAVSEA's 2024 dates. The ship deployed in March, and the next period, awarded in August, is expected to finish by October 2028. This desk found no award for the 2025 period on the 2024 or 2025 daily contract lists.

The August award is a different period. The Department of War's contract list for August 11 shows about $150 million to BAE Systems in San Diego for Boxer "during a fiscal 2027 selected restricted availability," expected to be completed by October 2028.

The period due to close now had two end dates. A NAVSEA spokeswoman told Breaking Defense in May 2024 that the fiscal 2025 availability would run "approximately 18 months, beginning in April 2025 and completing in October 2026." NAVSEA's synopsis of that solicitation, in an undated copy on BidNet, anticipated "a single award on or around December 2024" and an "expected completion in August 2026."

In November 2025 the ship was at sea. The Navy's May 2026 shipbuilding plan captions a photograph "USS Boxer (LHD 4) executes advanced tactical training in the Pacific, Nov. 22, 2025."

It was still at sea when the award came. Stars and Stripes reported in April that the Boxer group left San Diego in March with the 11th Marine Expeditionary Unit. USNI News reported on September 23 that the group was in the Arabian Sea and Indian Ocean.

That December 2024 award is the record this desk cannot find. The daily contract lists for 2024 and 2025 carry none for a Boxer availability, and the award notice on the System for Award Management site could not be read because its data service refuses this desk's access.

The deferred surface work lands in those years. USNI News reported on September 23 that availabilities moved out of 2026 reach private repair yards from early 2027 into 2028.

Put the dates in a row and they show a period that did not start when planned and a ship that deployed instead. The record is silent on whether the Navy deferred the period or the award fell through. Set against the 18 months planned last time, the October 2028 completion puts the start around April 2027. Expect the start no earlier than that spring, and the completion to move if the ship is home late or the package grows.

**WHY IT MATTERS**

**Bottom line:** An availability awarded while the ship is deployed is priced before the deployment's wear can be surveyed, so the wear arrives as growth after the start. Ask now who approves growth on that class of contract and how long each approval takes. The limit is the growth path, approvals or the planners who size it; which one is yours to find.

*Sources: Department of War contracts, Aug 11, 2026; Breaking Defense, May 30, 2024; NAVSEA solicitation N00024-24-R-4425 via BidNet, undated; U.S. Navy shipbuilding plan, May 2026; Stars and Stripes, Apr 8, 2026; USNI News, Sep 23, 2026*

## MAINTENANCE ENGINEERING & TECHNOLOGIES

### Norfolk technicians fix deployed ships by video; the sailor does the hands-on work

A deployed carrier had critical problems on half its ultra-high-frequency satellite communications, and the Norfolk shop that supports them talked the crew through the fix. The first kits went to sea in 30 days on interim authority and overhead money.

The Mid-Atlantic Regional Maintenance Center said on September 9 that the carrier had "critical issues" with half its ultra-high-frequency satellite communications. Its satellite communications branch in Norfolk, Code 283, diagnosed a bad fiber on screen and talked the crew through the fix. The kit, the Augmented Reality Maintenance System, ARMS, is glasses, a camera and a tablet on the unclassified or secret network.

Technician Marcus Thompson said it removes the need to fly out and he can see it "replacing the majority of Onboard Tech Assists and fly aways". An Onboard Tech Assist is a shore technician's visit to work a fault aboard.

Port Hueneme reported in September 2025 that nine assisted events had cut expert time by 92 percent and 94 percent "cost avoidance" against support sent to the ship. More than 20 kits went out in mid-August to a dozen-plus forward-deployed ships, more for Aegis Ashore and the Iwo Jima group, toward every deploying ship. Pacific Fleet type commanders were paying for it while the team sought a program sponsor.

Port Hueneme's commanding officer said in May 2025 the kit is for faults a sailor can fix with help from shore: "the sailor fixed the problem".

Matthew Cole and Nicholas Bernstein of Port Hueneme wrote up the fielding for the Naval Postgraduate School's acquisition research

symposium in April 2026. After a February 2025 demonstration, the team was asked to field it across the Nimitz strike group in about 30 days, and did, except one ship already gone. It went under a non-permanent alteration status, the fleet's risk-acceptance process and an urgent-deployment interim authority to test; the first barrier was no budget, met with the center's innovation money.

The same paper says an expert who still must go travels "with more information and the correct equipment". Any shore expert at a warfare center or regional maintenance center reaches it with nothing to install; hundreds of shore accounts exist. It puts kits on about half the surface fleet and estimates 3,600 expert travel hours saved.

Read against the nine events of September 2025, the April 2026 paper points the same way: fewer trips, the rest with the fault known. The limit moves to three things Norfolk does not control: the crew's skill, the ship's connection, and who pays for the kit, so far no program sponsor. Nine events and an in-house estimate are a first reading until a program office reports them.

> WHY IT MATTERS
> **Bottom line:** If your shop sends technicians to ships, find out whether the ships you support have kits and who issues your experts' shore accounts. Then find which limit binds: the ship's connection, the crew's hands-on skill, or who funds the kit next year.

*Sources: Mid-Atlantic Regional Maintenance Center via DVIDS, Sep 9, 2026; NSWC Port Hueneme via DVIDS, Sep 5, 2025; NSWC Port Hueneme via DVIDS, May 14, 2025; Naval Postgraduate School Acquisition Research Program, "Demo to Deployment in 30 Days: The ARMS Case Study", Apr 30, 2026*

## BUSINESS PRACTICES & STRATEGY

### The steam catapult plan was due October 12, and nothing public says it arrived

The order's sixty days produced design-change statements, a parts contract and no public plan.

The memorandum of August 13 gave the Secretary of War 60 days to plan replacing the Electromagnetic Aircraft Launch System (EMALS) and the weapons elevators on CVN-81, Doris Miller, with steam and hydraulics. Section 5 adds 90 days for a component repair center plan.

USNI News reported on August 24 that Adm. Daryl Caudle, the Chief of Naval Operations, said "that will be a significant design change."

Janes reported on October 13 that Huntington Ingalls chief executive Chris Kastner called the switch "a pretty significant design effort".

Stars and Stripes reported that Senate Armed Services chair Roger Wicker sees "overwhelming support" for EMALS, and five committee Democrats told the President on August 17 it "is not feasible".

Kato Engineering has had Miller's twelve EMALS energy storage units on contract since September 2023, per the Department of War's September 7, 2023 announcement.

The Department of War announced on September 18 a $49.3 million Kato contract to engineer, repair and support that subsystem on in-service carriers through 2031, with Kato its original equipment manufacturer per Military & Aerospace Electronics.

H.R. 8800, passed July 22, and S. 4784, reported June 15, carry the EMALS procurement line at the requested $36.9 million and no provision changing CVN-81's launch system.

The White House press secretary said on October 13 that Cleveland gets a 46,000-square-foot submarine component repair center, and gave no site, operator or date.

**What we said in August.** The 60-day plan to put steam catapults on Doris Miller would turn on suppliers and workforce rather than engineering, and the memo might not survive Congress. The plan was due October 12 and nothing public says it arrived, so the first half is not scorable, and the public words, a design change, lean against us. The second leans our way, untested.

On those facts, expect CVN-81 to keep EMALS. No plan from the Secretary of War is public, public words say design change, and the committee chair and five members oppose it. Both bills fund EMALS as requested and change nothing on CVN-81's launch system; a reversal needs money with no public request.

> WHY IT MATTERS
> **Bottom line:** Size Ford-class work to EMALS and its one-maker parts, and watch the 90-day repair center plan, which has a city before a plan.

*Sources: The White House, Aug 13, 2026; USNI News, Aug 24, 2026; Janes, Oct 13, 2026; Stars and Stripes, Aug 24, 2026; Sen. Blumenthal, Aug 17, 2026; Department of War contracts, Sep 7, 2023; Department of War contracts, Sep 18, 2026; Military & Aerospace Electronics, Sep 23, 2026; H.R. 8800, as passed the House; S. 4784, as reported; White House briefing via Roll Call, Oct 13, 2026*

No leadership column this week; nothing in the pipeline had a study behind it.

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The Waterfront Brief is compiled weekly by the B2 vault's research engine from primary sources and verified trade reporting. Scope: US shipbuilding, US Navy sustainment, and partners across the Indo-Pacific region; out-of-area items only when there is a direct, stated lesson. Freshness policy: every article's anchor source is under 12 months old; older material appears only as dated context or a flagged exception. A linked sentence means the named source says it, not that this desk has independently verified it. Corrections welcome; staged sources are retained for audit.

## UPCOMING EVENTS

Nearest first, filling the page. **Bold** marks a decision that closes inside the next 60 days. NSRP is the National Shipbuilding Research Program, the industry-Navy body that funds shared shipyard process research; SNAME is the Society of Naval Architects and Marine Engineers; NSL is the Naval Submarine League; SAE is SAE International, which runs the Department of War Maintenance Symposium; SNA is the Surface Navy Association; DSI is the Defense Strategies Institute; NDIA is the National Defense Industrial Association; AFCEA is the Armed Forces Communications and Electronics Association and USNI the U.S. Naval Institute; AMPP is the Association for Materials Protection and Performance; ASNE is the American Society of Naval Engineers; the AMDA Foundation is the Australian body that runs the Indo Pacific exposition.

| Dates | Event | Register by | Why it matters |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Oct 20-21, 2026** | NSRP Workforce & Compliance and Production Planning Joint Panel, Pensacola, FL (NSRP) | In-person closed Oct 8; virtual option offered | Workforce and production-planning panels, jointly; virtual option |
| **Oct 28-30, 2026** | SNAME Maritime Convention 2026, Royal Sonesta Houston Galleria, Houston, TX (SNAME) | Not printed | Workforce pipeline: naval architects, marine engineers and yard production people in one technical program |
| **Nov 12-13, 2026** | Naval Submarine League Annual Symposium 2026, Arlington, VA (NSL) | To be posted | Submarine industrial base: the submarine force and its yards set the year’s priorities |
| **Dec 8-11, 2026** | Department of War Maintenance Symposium 2026, Fort Lauderdale, FL (SAE for DoW) | **Open; rates rise after Nov 7** | Maintenance execution: the department-wide depot maintenance meeting |
| **Jan 12-14, 2027** | SNA National Symposium 2027, Arlington, VA (SNA) | Not yet open | Program priorities: where the surface force states its maintenance priorities |
| **Jan 26-28, 2027** | Military Additive Manufacturing Summit (MILAM), Tampa, FL (DSI) | Early rate closed Oct 2 | Additive qualification: defense additive qualification and NAVSEA-spec adoption |
| **Feb 8-10, 2027** | NDIA Annual Logistics Forum 2027, Renaissance Orlando at SeaWorld, Orlando, FL (NDIA) | Not printed | Supply chain: lifecycle sustainment and supply-chain community (the 41st forum) |
| **Feb 16-18, 2027** | WEST 2027, San Diego, CA (AFCEA/USNI) | Not printed | Program priorities: the Pacific-side sea services conference |
| **Mar 23-25, 2027** | NSRP All Panel Meeting 2027, North Charleston, SC (NSRP) | “Coming soon” | Regional capacity: where yard R&D ideas get teamed program-wide |
| **Apr 4-7, 2027** | Sea-Air-Space 2027, National Harbor, MD (Navy League) | Not yet open | Program priorities: the largest US maritime defense exposition |
| **Apr 11-15, 2027** | AMPP Annual Conference + Expo 2027, Columbus, Ohio (AMPP) | Abstracts closed Oct 1; attendee registration not printed | Preservation: the corrosion and coatings profession’s main event |
| **Jun 8-10, 2027** | MegaRust 2027, Hampton, VA (ASNE) | Attendee registration not yet open | Maintenance execution: the Navy corrosion event |